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The Portable Document Format (PDF)

The Portable Document Format, universally known as PDF, was developed by Adobe Systems in the early 1990s as a solution to a pervasive problem in digital communication: how to share documents that look identical regardless of the device, operating system, or software used to view them. Introduced by Adobe co-founder John Warnock through his "Camelot" project, the format was officially launched in 1993. Before PDF, sending a formatted document across different computers was a gamble — fonts would change, layouts would break, and carefully designed pages would arrive looking nothing like the original. PDF solved this by embedding everything a document needs — fonts, images, vector graphics, and layout instructions — into a single, self-

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